1976STATE255220 - State Department to Embassy Seoul, 14 Oct 1976 (142334Z)
US Department of State, Central Foreign Policy Files, 1973-79 (NARA RG 59).
Declassified/released 2004 (EO Systematic Review). Verbatim text of the
electronic telegram; text retrieved from https://wikileaks.org/plusd/cables/1976STATE255220_b.html
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ORIGIN EA-09

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NSAE-00 NSC-05 PA-01 PRS-01 SP-02 SS-15 USIA-06

CAB-02 COME-00 DOTE-00 EB-07 CIEP-01 FAA-00 SAM-01

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DRAFTED BY EA/K:FMISCH:CHG
APPROVED BY EA/K:EHURWITZ
DOD/ISA: COL HARRIS
EB/OA/AVP- MR KEITER
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P 142334Z OCT 76
FM SECSTATE WASHDC
TO AMEMBASSY SEOUL PRIORITY

C O N F I D E N T I A L STATE 255220

E.O. 11652: GDS

TAGS:PFOR, MILI, EAIR, KS, US

SUBJECT: CAPITOL GUARD FIRING ON NORTHWEST AIRCRAFT

REF: COMUSKOREA 141321Z

1. DEPARTMENT RECEIVED CONSIDERABLE NUMBER OF CALLS ON INCIDENT AND WE HAVE RESPONDED ALONG LINES OF FOLLOWING GUIDANCE:

QUOTE:
QUESTION: WHAT CAN YOU TELL US ABOUT THE KOREANS SHOOTING AT A NORTHWEST AIRLINES PLANE OVER SEOUL?

ANSWER: WE HAVE A REPORT FROM THE KOREAN GOVERNMENT THAT ON THE 14TH AT 1813 LOCAL TIME NORTHWEST CARGO FLIGHT 902, AS IT TOOK OFF FROM KIMPO AIRFIELD BOUND FOR TOKYO,
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ENTERED THE RESTRICTED AREA AROUND THE CAPITOL, FLYING AT 8000 FEET, CAPITOL SECURITY FORCES FIRED OVER 1000 ROUNDS AT THE AIRCRAFT. THE AIRCRAFT SUBSEQUENTLY LANDED SAFETY IN TOKYO. IT HAD NOT BEEN HIT, AND THE CREW STATED THEY WERE NOT AWARE THEY HAD BEEN FIRED UPON.

AT 1832, CAPITOL SECURITY FORCES FIRED ABOUT 700 ROUNDS AT A SUSPECTED UNIDENTIFIED PROPELLER DRIVEN AIRCRAFT.

NO U.S. AIRCRAFT WERE INVOLVED IN THIS. THERE ARE REPORTED INJURIES TO SEVERAL PERSONS FROM FALLING SHRAPNEL.

QUESTION: IS THIS SHOOTING GALLERY PROCEDURE ROUTINE?

ANSWER: SINCE THE JANUARY 1968 NORTH KOREAN RAID ON THE CAPITOL, SECURITY PRECAUTIONS IN THE AREA HAVE BEEN STRICT. PLANES WHICH HAVE STRAYED INTO RESTRICTED AREAS HAVE BEEN FIRED UPON AS A MATTER OF COURSE.

QUESTION: WAS THIS PLANE INSIDE THE AREA?

ANSWER: WE CANNOT CONFIRM THIS PRECISELY AT THIS TIME.

END QUOTE.

NO QUESTIONS ON INCIDENT WERE ASKED AT NOON BRIEFING.

2. WHILE WE ARE AWARE OF REASONS FOR TIGHT SECURITY AROUND CAPITOL, WE ARE NEVERTHELESS CONCERNED ABOUT THE QUICK TRIGGER ATTITUDE OF THE ROK ANTI-AIRCRAFT GUNNERS AS WELL AS THE APPARENT LACK OF COORDINATION BETWEEN CAPITOL DEFENSE FORCE AND KIMPO AIRCRAFT CONTROL AUTHORITIES. WE BELIEVE THAT ROKG WOULD AGREE THAT SHOOTDOWN OF LARGE COMMERCIAL AIRCRAFT, CARGO OR PASSENGER, OVER THE CITY WOULD RESULT IN CATASTROPHE OF MAJOR PROPORTIONS.

3. ACCORDINGLY, EMBASSY SHOULD MAKE USG CONCERNS OVER INCIDENT KNOWN TO ROKG AT APPROPRIATE LEVELS IN APPROPRIATE MINISTRIES STRESSING POTENTIAL DANGER OF INDISCRIMINATE FIRING AND OUR IMPRESSION THAT FIRE

CONTROL DISCIPLINE SHOULD BE IMPROVED.

4. DEPARTMENT WOULD APPRECIATE EMBASSY VIEWS AS TO UTILITY OF POSSIBLE US-ROK TECHNICAL CONSULTATIONS TO SEEK MEANS OF BETTER AVOIDING POTENTIAL DISASTER IF COMMERCIAL AIRCRAFT IN FUTURE INADVERTENTLY ENTER PROHIBITED ZONE NEAR CAPITOL.

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1976SEOUL08287 - Embassy Seoul to State Department, 15 Oct 1976 (151011Z)
US Department of State, Central Foreign Policy Files, 1973-79 (NARA RG 59).
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DOTE-00 EB-07 CIEP-01 FAA-00 SAM-01 NSCE-00 SSO-00

USIE-00 INRE-00 IO-13 /074 W
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O R 151011Z OCT 76
FM AMEMBASSY SEOUL
TO SECSTATE WASHDC IMMEDIATE 0044
INFO SECDEF
JCS

C O N F I D E N T I A L SEOUL 8287

EO 11652: GDS
TAGS: PFOR, MILI, EAIR, KS
SUBJECT: FIRING ON NORTHWEST AIRCRAFT

REF: (A) STATE 255220, (B) COMUSKK 141301Z

1. FOLLOWING IS SUMMARY OF DEVELOPMENTS SINCE REFTEL B.

2. AFTERNOON OF OCTOBER 15 ROK MINISTRY OF DEFENSE ISSUED FOLLOWING:

ROK MND ANNOUNCED TODAY, 15 OCT 1976, THAT LAST NIGHT AT APPROXIMATELY 1819 HOURS (14 OCT), SEOUL ANTI AIRCRAFT BATTERIES FIRED WARNING SHOTS AGAINST UNKNOWN/UNIDENTIFIED AIRCRAFT. RESULTS OF INVESTIGATION REVEALED THAT THE AIRCRAFT WAS A BOEING 707 NUMBER 902, CHARTERED CARGO PLANE.

IT IS CONFIRMED THAT THE AIRCRAFT DEPARTED KIMPO AIRPORT FOR OSAKA, JAPAN AND VIOLATED P-73 WHILE ENROUTE DUE TO A NAVIGATIONAL ERROR.

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UNFORTUNATELY, MANY CITIZENS WERE WOUNDED DURING THE WARNING FIRE. MND EXPRESSES DEEP REGRET THEREFORE, AND CONCERNING COMPENSATION FOR INJURY TO PERSONS OR PROPERTY, AND WILL PROVIDE PROMPT AND PROPER MEASURES.

3. EARLIER IN DAY, VICE MINISTER OF DEFENSE YI MIN U TOLD

NATIONAL ASSEMBLY DEFENSE COMMITTEE THAT 21 PERSONS HAD BEEN INJURED, 8 SERIOUSLY. NO DEATHS HAVE BEEN REPORTED, AND EMBASSY HAS NO REPORT OF INJURIES TO AMERICANS. HOWEVER, PROJECTILES AND FRAGMENTS LANDED IN EMBASSY AND UNC RESIDENCE AREAS AND THERE WAS NEGIBLE PROPERTY DAMAGE.

4. INVESTIGATION BY ROK MND, AS INFORMLLY REPORTED TO UNC, INDICATES THAT AIRCRAFT WAS GIVEN INCORRECT ROUTING BY KIMPO AIR TRAFFIC CONTROL. THIS WAS CORRECTED BUT NOT UNTIL PLANE HAD NEARED, OR POSSIBLY ENTERED, PROHIBITED AIR SPACE.

5. EMBASSY HAS EXPRESSED CONCERN INFORMALLY TO ROK OFFICIALS, INCLUDING DIRECTOR OF JCS STAFF, LT. GEN YU PYONG HYON, WHO ATTENDED RECEPTION AT EMBASSY COMPOUND THAT EVENING AND WAS GIVEN FRAGMENT OF PROJECTILE THAT FELL INTO COMPOUND DURING FIRING. WE WILL BE MAKING FURTHER APPROACHES ON FORMAL BASIS IN NEXT FEW DAYS.

6. AS REGARDS CORRECTIVE ACTION, IT IS IMPORTANT TO NOTE THAT INCORRECT DIRECTIVE FROM ATC DOES NOT RELIEVE PILOT OF RESPONSIBILITY FOR CORRECT NAVIGATION OF AIRCRAFT AND FOR AVOIDANCE OF PROHIBITED AREAS. VISIBILITY AT TIME WAS ADEQUATE TO SEE HIGH-INTENSITY
STROBE LIGHTS THAT SURROUND CITY AND ELECTRONIC NAVAIDS ALSO AVAILABLE. HOWEVER, WE AGREE THAT SHOOTING DOWN OF COMMERCIAL AIRCRAFT OVER SEOUL WOULD BE CATASTROPHE AND WE BELIEVE ROKG IS NOW MORE SENSITIVE TO THIS ISSUE THAN IT MAY HAVE BEEN IN PAST. ISSUE OF CONTROL OVER ANTI-AIRCRAFT BATTERIES IN CAPITOL AREA HAS ALSO BEEN UNDER DISCUSSION WITH ROKG DURING RECENT MONTHS AND USFK EXPECTS TO MAKE FURTHER SPECIFIC PROPOSALS IN NEAR FUTURE. FURTHER RESPONSE TO REF A IN PREPARATION.

7. LOCAL NWA MANAGER HAS ASKED FOR INFORMATION, NOTING THAT
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HE HAS NO DIRECT KNOWLEDGE OF INCIDENT. WE PLAN TO INFORM HIM OF GIST OF INVESTIGATION, BUT URGE THAT NO PUBLIC STATEMENTS BE MADE, IN VIEW OF APPARENT ROKG WILLINGNESS TO MAKE COMPENSATION AND DESIRABILITY OF PURSUING RESOLUTION WITHOUT CAUSING ROKG FURTHER PUBLIC EMBARASSMENT.
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